

Red Level: Go Deeper

Name: _____ Date: _____ Period: _____

Critical Frame: Duke Ellington said: "Jazz is not just music — it is a way of life, a way of feeling, a way of thinking." Analyse one recording's full structural architecture, then compose an original phrase within the blues framework, and write a critical essay connecting jazz structure to its cultural and historical context.

ACTIVITY 1: FULL STRUCTURAL ANALYSIS

Analyse One Recording in Depth

Recording selected: _____

Element	What you hear	What it does — function or effect
Harmonic structure (12-bar / other)		
Syncopation (where / how)		
Call-and-response (which instruments)		
Improvisation (who / when)		
Rhythm section role		
Dynamics / expression		

What is the single most striking musical choice in this recording? Why?

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ACTIVITY 2: COMPOSITION TASK

Write a 4-Bar Melody Over the Blues

Using the 12-bar blues framework (bars 1–4 are chord I), write an original 4-bar melody. Use standard notation, solfège, or letter names for each beat. Your melody must include at least one syncopated note (off-beat accent) and one "blue note" (flattened 3rd or 7th).

Key of C — Bars 1–4 all use chord C (I). Time signature: 4/4

BAR 1 — C

Beat 1 + Beat 2 + Beat 3 +
Beat 4 +

BAR 2 — C

Beat 1 + Beat 2 + Beat 3 +
Beat 4 +

BAR 3 — C

Beat 1 + Beat 2 + Beat 3 +
Beat 4 +

BAR 4 — C

Beat 1 + Beat 2 + Beat 3 +
Beat 4 +

Where did you place your syncopated note? Bar _____, beat _____

What blue note did you use? _____ What effect does it create?

ACTIVITY 3: CRITICAL ESSAY

Duke Ellington said jazz is "a way of life, a way of feeling, a way of thinking." Using your structural analysis and what you know about the Harlem Renaissance, write 4–5 sentences arguing: what did jazz make possible for Black Americans in the 1920s that other art forms could not?

Mini Museum Deep Dive

In the **Jazz Lab**, isolate the rhythm section (bass, drums, piano). Listen to how the music changes without it. What does the rhythm section actually do — is it accompaniment, or something more fundamental? How does your answer connect to the African rhythmic traditions that gave jazz its foundation?

minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance